

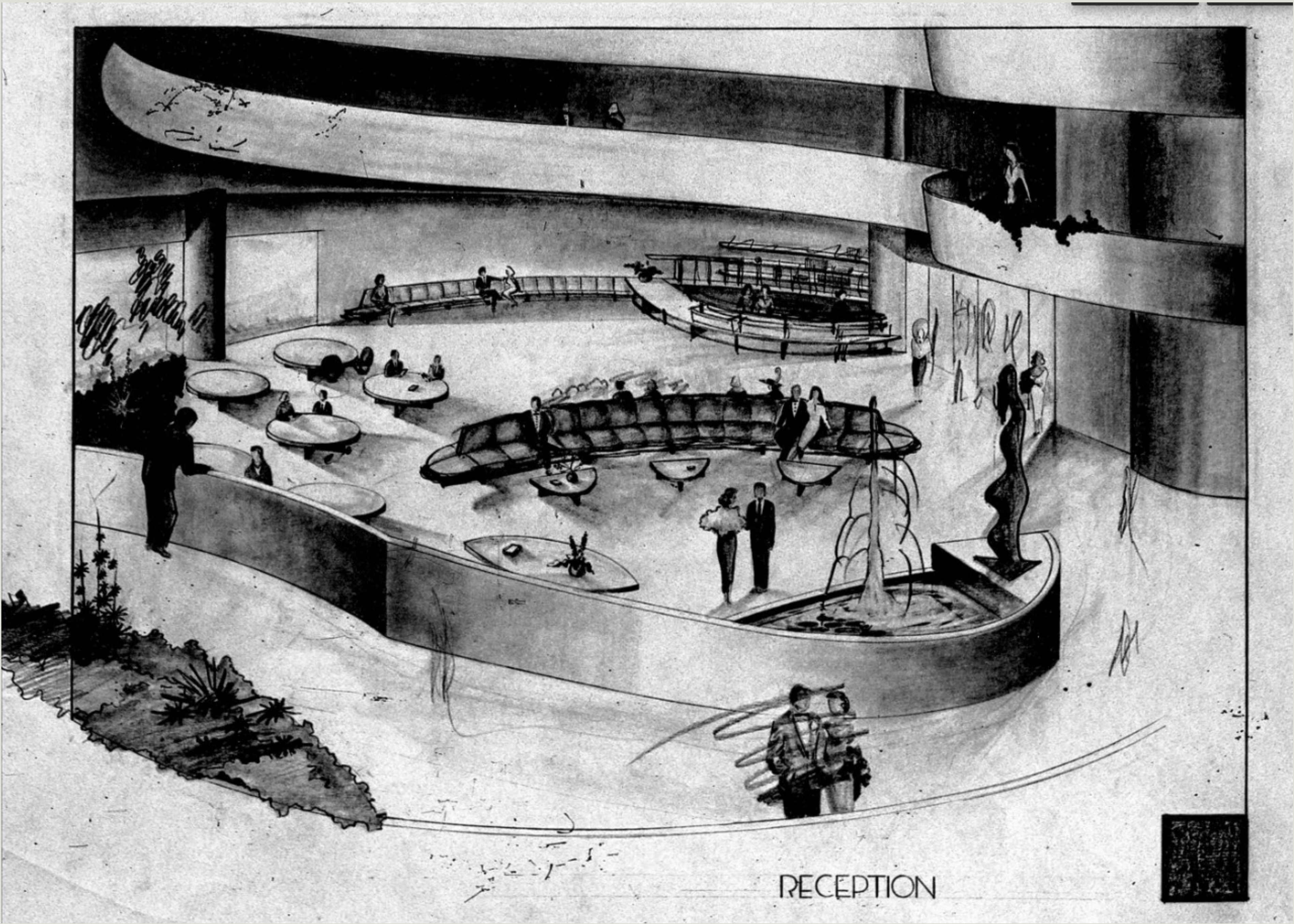
QUEUE

HOLD

GUGGENHEIM RECEPTION



The Upper East Side is part of what would become Museum Mile, and during this period was the cultural district of New York’s elite. In the same years, Black residents were being redlined out of this neighborhood. Exhibiting modernist art here in the 1940s and 50s was an act of cultural geography because Solomon R. Guggenheim was building an exhibition featuring specifically non-objective, abstract European work that required cultural literacy and paid admission to access. The drawing of the reception area and process designs of seating assume a visitor that already has the leisure to be there. The Guggenheim has also been widely criticized for the famously panopticon condition of the main rotunda, yet Wright’s sketches project the “comfortable visitor” as someone who is not hyper aware of their exposure in a predominantly white, wealthy, cultural institution. They showcase a specific social experience of waiting that presupposes the participant has already attained the standards of the institution.



Frank Lloyd Wright, Reception and Café Waiting Area, Solomon R. Guggenheim Museum, New York. Architectural drawing with furniture plans, 1943–1956. Avery Architectural and Fine Arts Library, Columbia University.

